WHAT IF?! EP 01

FREE GUIDE
you commented FUNK

The Funk Timeline

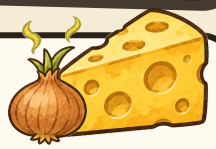


Day 1 to day 365 of not showering. What really happens to you, your sheets and your skin. No study of a full year exists, so the long stretch is extrapolated, and each stop says which bits are science.

SCIENCE sourced MATHS my arithmetic JOKE not a study

DAY 1-2

The smell starts



SCIENCE Sweat itself has no smell. Bacteria (key species *Staphylococcus hominis*) eat an odourless sweat compound and release a gas that smells cheesy and oniony.

WEEKS 1-3

The pile-up



DERMATOLOGISTS SAY Oil, dirt and dead skin build up, pores clog, acne gets likelier, and a graze has a slightly bigger chance of getting infected. Your skin bacteria shift too.

DAY 30

Your sheets become a buffet



MATHS You shed about 1.5 g of skin a day, so about 45 g by now, and it lands in your bed. An average bed already holds roughly 100,000 to 1,000,000+ dust mites (only about 5% alive).

MONTH 3

Cornflakes. Yes, really.



CASE REPORTS Patches that will not wipe off: brown, crusty, stuck-on scales like cornflakes. The condition is **dermatitis neglecta**, described in the medical literature since 1995. It is usually patchy, not whole-body.

DAY 182

Half way: a quarter kilo of you



MATHS About 270 g of shed skin by now, in your clothes, sheets and couch. And the mites? You already had them: in a 2014 study, *Demodex* mite DNA turned up on every adult face sampled (a small group, and it is DNA, not eyeballs).

DAY 365

One year: half a kilo



MATHS 1.5 g x 365 is about 550 g of shed skin, roughly a bag of flour, mostly living in your sheets. Verdict from science: no study exists. JOKE Verdict from the bus: you are now a rumour.

Sources Poskitt et al., Br J Dermatol 1995 / PMC4372914 (dermatitis neglecta) · York team, Scientific Reports 2020 (armpit odour) · Australian Geographic 2010, CSIRO (dust mites) · National Geographic 2014 (face mites)

The rubbing-alcohol rescue

A year of filth, undone by a pad from a first-aid kit. Here is what the case reports actually describe.



STEP 1

Wipe a patch with an alcohol swab

In the case literature the swab is both the test and the treatment: the scale wipes off and normal skin appears underneath.



STEP 2

If it hangs on, wash gently, daily

Gentle daily scrubbing with a mild cleanser cleared a lesion in about a month in the reports. Patience, not violence.

STEP 3

Get it looked at if unsure

It is often mistaken for warts, psoriasis or acanthosis nigricans, so a doctor can confirm what it is.

SEE A DOCTOR IF a patch will not clear after gentle washing, it is changing, painful or you are not sure what it is, or you are unable to wash because of illness, pain or limited mobility. Reported causes include disability, immobility after a fall and mental illness, so it is not simply laziness.

Fact or funk?

Claim	What the sources say
"Sweat stinks."	**NO** Sweat is odourless. Bacteria eating it make the smell.
"Your feet make cheese."	**SORT OF** No cheese. But foot-odour bacteria include relatives of the ones that ripen stinky cheese.
"Showering more is always better."	**DEBATED** A 2023 study linked more-than-daily bathing to worse eczema; less-than-daily was not linked to worse outcomes. Cleveland Clinic dermatologists still recommend a daily one.
"A scientist went 12+ years without showering."	**SELF-REPORTED** Dave Whitlock said so in 2015 and sprayed bacteria instead. An outside expert saw no evidence any particular bacterium helps.
"The world's dirtiest man."	**REPORTEDLY** Amou Haji of Iran reportedly did not wash for 60+ years and died aged 94 in 2022. That does not show the dirt, or the bath, did anything.



The moral

You can skip the shower. You just can not skip the sheets. This is comedy about science, not a plan: dermatologists do not say to stop showering.

Sources escholarship.org/uc/item/04v3r596 and PMC4372914 (dermatitis neglecta, alcohol swab) · PubMed 36917546 (Dermatitis 2023, bathing and eczema) · Cleveland Clinic newsroom, Jan 2025 · LiveScience (Whitlock) · The National, Oct 2022 (Amou Haji)